

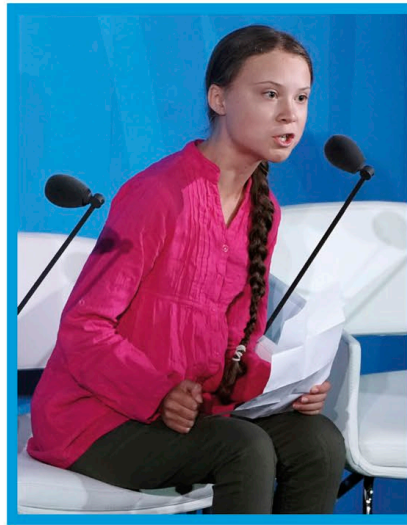
jurisdiction on a discretionary basis. The Security Council is authorized by the UN Charter to enforce the Court's rulings, but any of the P5 can veto such a move, which is what the US did over Nicaragua.

In 2002, an International Criminal Court was established to work with the ICJ to try individuals, not nations, for crimes such as genocide.

### One world?

Through the ages, countless great thinkers—such as 16th-century Spanish philosopher Francisco de Vitoria—have wondered if all problems might be solved if there was just one government for the entire world. The logic is simple: wars seem to be fought at the behest of governments and rulers, so if there was just a single government or ruler, there would be no wars.

In 1943, one-time US presidential candidate Wendell Willkie wrote the bestselling book *One World*, in which he proposed a global federation. In 1945, in *The Anatomy of Peace*, Hungarian Emery Reves argued that an association of states such as the United Nations could never prevent war and that it should therefore be replaced by a federal



**Swedish schoolgirl Greta Thunberg** has made headline news all over the world with her no-nonsense environmental activism voiced at high-profile UN events.

to control arms. But any such vision rapidly evaporated in the postwar descent into a new “Cold War” between the USSR, driven by Lenin’s vision of the Bolshevik World State, and the US-led West, which believed in a world dominated by democratic nation-states and global capitalism.

The UN became accepted as the best compromise. In many ways, it turned out to be more of a success than commentators had feared, and it has provided a forum that has given a voice to a lot of rising nations. Yet in the 21st century, it seems unable to deal with conflicts in the Middle East, global terrorism, refugees, and trafficking. Additionally, as teenage climate activist Greta Thunberg so powerfully pointed out in her address to the General Assembly in 2019, the UN appears toothless in the face of the biggest crisis of all: global climate change and its impact on all of humanity. ■

world government. The horror of the atomic bombs dropped on the Japanese cities of Hiroshima and Nagasaki in 1945 gave further impetus to the idea of a world government. German physicist Albert Einstein was one of the many high-profile campaigners who were deeply disturbed by the unprecedented destructive power of nuclear weapons.

More and more people began to call for the new United Nations to be transformed into a universal federation of states with the power



**The 1989 Convention** sets out a child’s rights, including those concerning child labor—such as at this open-cast mine in Jharia, India.

### The UN Convention on the Rights of the Child

One of the major successes of the United Nations is in relation to human rights. Over the decades, a comprehensive body of human rights law has been set up to act as a benchmark for people seeking to protect rights, including civil, cultural, economic, political, and social rights.

A landmark achievement was the UN Convention on the Rights of the Child, which was adopted in 1989. Every signatory must report regularly to the UN committee on their progress in this area. The

Convention insists every child must have basic human rights, including the right to life; to their own name and identity; to an education that enables them to fulfill their potential; to be raised by or have a relationship with their parents; and to express their opinions and be listened to. Under two special protocols, it also prohibits the involvement of children in warfare, the trafficking of children, child prostitution, and child pornography.